ultimate goal of marriage is to develop love between the couple and thus considers the love-marriage to be the pre-eminent form of marriage'.[26]

Polygamy and adultery had been common in high society across India during the half millennium preceding the Chandelas. 'Kings, noblemen and the wealthy had as many wives as they could afford' and as per their social status, writes Desai. Their wives too had lots of affairs, if on the sly. During royal parties, 'city women and wives of chiefs took [alcoholic] drinks in the company of men and mixed freely with them'. Prostitution was legal and taxed, and the women had 'some legal protection'.[27] The state apparently stipulated 'punishments for various categories of rape', including 'physically branding the rapist'.[28]

Rich, powerful men sought the company of courtesans, who were educated, cultured, upper-class women proficient in the 'sixty-four arts' of refinement, such as music, dance and *ars erotica*. They could choose their clients and apparently 'lived in a special quarter of the city, either independently or financed by the king'—an upscale area visited by the elite, rather than a seedy red-light district. 'Although roundly condemned by the clergy, courtesans were immensely popular and admired, just like modern celebrities.'[29] Many kings and aristocrats kept concubines and took them on 'hunting expeditions, picnics to gardens, water-sports, summer resorts and also to battles'.[30] A man's concubines were sometimes even expected to regale his honoured guests.